



FEBRUARY – THE BRIDGE BETWEEN WINTER AND SPRING

February can feel like a month caught between two seasons.

Winter still has a firm grip on the weather.

Cold nights remain common.

Storms and wet conditions are still possible.

Yet signs of spring are beginning to appear.

The days are noticeably longer.

Early flowers begin to emerge.

Many colonies start expanding their brood nests.

For beekeepers, February is a month of careful observation and preparation.

The colony is changing rapidly, even if much of that change remains hidden inside the hive.

WINTER IS NOT OVER YET

One of the biggest mistakes new beekeepers make is assuming spring has arrived.

A few mild days can create the impression that winter is ending.

The reality is often very different.

February can bring:

- Heavy rain
- Strong winds
- Frost
- Snow
- Sudden cold snaps

Colonies remain vulnerable to prolonged poor weather.

Food stores can disappear quickly if bees are unable to forage.

Patience remains essential.

WHAT THE BEES ARE DOING

Inside the hive, activity is increasing.



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Many queens begin laying more consistently.

The brood nest slowly expands.

As brood numbers increase, the colony's food requirements rise dramatically.

Brood must be kept warm.

Workers generate heat continuously.

The colony now faces a balancing act.

It must support growing brood while still surviving winter conditions.

This is why February can be one of the most critical months of the year.

FOOD STORES BECOME EVEN MORE IMPORTANT

February is often regarded as the starvation month.

Not because there is less food available.

But because consumption increases rapidly.

A colony that appeared heavy in January may become surprisingly light by the end of February.

Regular hefting remains one of the most valuable skills a beekeeper can develop.

Every visit to the apiary should include a quick assessment of hive weight.

If a colony feels light, action should be taken immediately.

CONTINUE FEEDING FONDANT IF NEEDED

Fondant remains the safest emergency feed during February.

As brood rearing increases, colonies may consume feed more quickly than expected.

Many experienced beekeepers prefer to leave fondant in place until consistent spring forage becomes available.

There is little benefit in risking starvation.

There is considerable benefit in ensuring the colony always has access to food.

When feeding:

- Place fondant directly above the cluster
- Minimise disturbance
- Work quickly
- Avoid prolonged exposure of brood to cold air



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EARLY SPRING FORAGE

One of the most encouraging sights in February is seeing bees returning with pollen.

Depending on location and weather, forage may include:

- Snowdrops
- Crocus
- Hazel
- Mahonia
- Winter honeysuckle
- Early willow in warmer areas

Bright pollen loads indicate brood is being reared.

The colony is beginning to invest in the future.

However, forage remains inconsistent.

Do not assume that pollen collection means food shortages can no longer occur.

WATCH FOR CLEANSING FLIGHTS

Mild days often trigger noticeable activity at the hive entrance.

Bees may fly in significant numbers for short periods.

These are frequently cleansing flights.

Workers leave the hive to relieve themselves after extended periods of confinement.

Seeing activity on suitable days is generally reassuring.

It suggests the colony remains alive and functioning normally.

RESIST THE TEMPTATION TO INSPECT TOO EARLY

Many beekeepers become eager to inspect colonies during February.

The increasing activity can create the impression that conditions are suitable.

Often they are not.

Opening a hive too early can:

- Chill brood
- Disrupt the cluster
- Increase food consumption



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- Stress the colony

Most information can still be gathered externally.

Observe:

- Flight activity
- Pollen collection
- Hive weight
- Signs of damage
- Entrance condition

Leave full inspections until genuinely suitable spring weather arrives.

CHECKING FOR MOISTURE AND MOULD

Late winter is often when moisture issues become apparent.

A small amount of mould on unused comb or the crownboard is not unusual.

Bees generally clean minor mould naturally once activity increases.

More significant concerns include:

- Excess condensation
- Wet comb
- Water ingress
- Persistent dampness

The goal is not maximum ventilation.

The goal is a dry hive.

Dry colonies generally overwinter far better than damp ones.

VARROA RECORDS AND HEALTH PLANNING

February is a useful month for reviewing colony health records.

Consider:

- Previous mite levels
- Treatments used
- Colonies that struggled last season
- Colonies that performed strongly



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Good planning now often prevents problems later.

Spring management begins long before the first inspection.

PREPARING EQUIPMENT FOR SPRING

Spring arrives quickly.

Often faster than expected.

February is one of the last opportunities to prepare equipment before colonies begin expanding rapidly.

Tasks include:

- Building frames
- Fitting foundation
- Repairing boxes
- Cleaning floors
- Preparing supers
- Organising spare equipment

Many beekeepers regret delaying these jobs.

Few regret completing them early.

THINKING ABOUT SWARM CONTROL

Actual swarm control is still some way off.

Planning for it is not.

Strong colonies can develop rapidly once spring arrives.

February is an excellent time to:

- Review swarm control methods
- Prepare spare brood boxes
- Assemble nucleus equipment
- Decide how increases will be managed

Preparation reduces panic later in the season.

LEARNING AND EDUCATION

February remains an excellent month for learning.



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Many associations continue winter lecture programmes and training events.

Popular topics include:

- Queen rearing
- Swarm management
- Honey production
- Disease recognition
- Varroa control

Knowledge gained during winter often proves most valuable during spring.

THE FIRST HINTS OF SPRING

By the end of February, noticeable changes are often occurring.

The days are longer.

Pollen collection becomes more common.

Brood nests expand.

The colony begins transitioning from winter survival to spring growth.

The pace of change remains slow.

Yet the direction is clear.

Spring is approaching.

LOOKING TOWARDS MARCH

March marks the beginning of the active beekeeping season for many beekeepers.

Weather permitting, the first meaningful inspections may become possible.

Brood production accelerates.

Food demand increases.

Colony growth begins in earnest.

February serves as the bridge that connects winter survival with spring development.

Success in March often depends upon decisions made during February.

FEBRUARY TAKEAWAY

February is a month of transition.

The colony is no longer simply surviving winter.



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It is preparing for spring.

Monitor food carefully.

Watch for signs of brood rearing.

Keep colonies dry.

Prepare equipment.

Remain patient.

The season is about to change.

REALITY CHECK: Most colonies that die in late winter do not die from cold. They die because growing brood causes food consumption to increase faster than the beekeeper realises.